2.2 Hardship and Challenges

Even the most satisfying success can be short-lived, especially in wartime. You're up one day and down the next. Challenging as it may be, you just have to hang in there.

MAIN IDEA The Continental Army faced hardship and challenges at Valley Forge and on the frontier.

VALLEY FORGE

As you have read, the victory at Saratoga boosted American morale, but there was much more work to be done. The focus of the war shifted to Pennsylvania, where General Howe now occupied Philadelphia. You probably remember that the Continental Army set up camp at **Valley Forge**, northwest of the city, in the dead of the winter of 1777. George Washington set up camp alongside his men high atop a series of hills. Washington vowed to "share in the hardship" and "partake of [take part in] every inconvenience" his soldiers



CRITICAL VIEWING William T. Trego based this 1883 painting on a line from literature: "Sad and dreary was the march to Valley Forge." What details in the painting convey the soldiers' weariness?

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experienced. While Washington certainly suffered, he lived with his aides in a stone house at Valley Forge. His men lived in the small wooden huts they'd built themselves and used straw they gathered for bedding.

Meanwhile, General **Henry Clinton** had become the new commander of British forces in North America. In contrast to the Americans, Clinton and his men settled into quarters in Philadelphia, where they lived in relative comfort. Loyalist families gave them places to stay, and Clinton and his officers enjoyed parties and good food.

As you've read, the soldiers in the Continental Army suffered greatly from the cold and a lack of food, and some chose to **desert**, or run away from the army. But despite the horrible conditions, most soldiers chose to stay. Loyal to General Washington and determined to keep up the fight, they spent the winter training under von Steuben.



As winter wore on, others arrived to help the American cause. Lafayette came to command a division at Valley Forge. In addition to sharing his men's hardships, the Frenchman provided uniforms and muskets to those who needed them.

Spring's arrival brought not only better weather but also great news. Word of the alliance between America and France reached the camp. To celebrate, Washington had his men line up and shoot their guns in the air. They were poised and ready to do battle at Monmouth.

WAR ON THE FRONTIER

Pennsylvania wasn't the only place where war raged. From New York to Georgia, **skirmishes**, or small, short battles, took place along the rural western boundary of the frontier. Small divisions of the British Army guarded forts in this region, supported by Native American volunteers. Remember that at the outset of the American Revolution, many Native Americans supported the British. They feared that if the Americans won, they would take over more Native American land.

British general Henry Hamilton and his Native American allies planned to invade the frontier. But American frontiersman George Rogers Clark heard of these plans and led a small force in a surprise attack on one of the British bases, Fort Vincennes (vihn-SEHNZ). Hamilton surrendered, and the joint British–Native American offensive was halted.

Despite Clark's victory at Vincennes, American settlers found themselves constantly battling Iroquois forces. The fighting caused homelessness and food shortages in many communities.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What did George Washington's men have to do when they first arrived at Valley Forge?
2. **COMPARE AND CONTRAST** How did the experiences of the British and Continental armies in the winter of 1777–78 differ?
3. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** How and why did Native Americans participate in the American Revolution?

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